

After he had driven out of sight, his mom Sara looked for her husband James and couldn't find him. She searched everywhere and finally found him in Christopher's room crying. This took her by surprise since James rarely showed emotion. He sobbed, "Our baby boy has left us." His sorrow was short lived. Three months later, Christopher moved back in.

Christopher ended up staying with his parents for one year. The second time he moved out, this event wasn't accompanied by as much fanfare. As Christopher left the house and the door closed behind him, James turned to Sara and said, "Honey, open a bottle of wine. I need a drink."

Three months later, Christopher was back. This time, he again stayed for one year. By now, James had gotten over the sorrow of losing his son and was beginning to think that his son would end up living with them forever. When it came time for Christopher to move out the third time, there was no fanfare at all. As soon as the door closed behind his son, James said, "Sara, call a locksmith fast and change the locks!"

Nowadays, parents shouldn't expect to become empty nesters when their youngest child turns eighteen. According to the Bureau of the Census, most children do not leave home until the age of twenty-four. I've recently talked to numerous parents who say their children last approximately ninety days on their own the first time they move out. Why ninety days? It might have something to do with the fact that after ninety days of nonpayment, the credit card companies start calling you to find out when you intend to pay. It also takes around ninety days to have your phone and utility services disconnected for nonpayment. At the end of ninety days, the stack of dirty laundry is probably very high and the refrigerator very empty. Suddenly, living under your parents' rule doesn't seem quite so bad.

Sara and James' increasing frustration with their son's annual return home was most certainly also felt by

